

WWII FIGHTERS AND FIGHTER-BOMBERS

WWII FIGHTER AIRCRAFT were asked to perform in a variety of roles.

Fighters had to battle for air superiority with their opposite numbers on the enemy side; act as interceptors against enemy bombers; fulfill a ground attack role in support of armies; act as bomber escorts; and operate as night fighters. Although many aircraft worked well in several roles, none could excel at them all. In general the best air-superiority fighters were light single-seaters, fast in a dive and tight in a turn, such as the Spitfire and Messerschmitt Bf 109. The interceptor role suited aircraft that provided a stable gun platform with heavy firepower, such as the Hurricane. Heavier fighters that could take punishment and carry a substantial armament – such as the Hawker Typhoon and P-47 Thunderbolt – excelled at ground attack. The best night fighters were two- or three-seaters, because the pilot needed someone to operate complex radio and radar equipment.

Escort fighters required the range to accompany bombers to their targets plus the fighting ability to see off enemy interceptors. The North American Mustang was peerless in this role.

SUPER SPITFIRE

The Supermarine Spitfire first entered service with the RAF in 1938 and remained in production during WWII. See pages 210–11.



Bell P-39D Airacobra

The American Airacobra is unusual in having the engine behind the pilot. This allowed room for the 20mm or 37mm cannon to fire through the propeller shaft. Although the P-39's performance was poor at high altitude, it was very effective at ground attack, making it a valuable fighter on the Eastern Front.



ENGINE 1,150hp Allison V-1710-35 liquid-cooled V-12 cylinder

WINGSPAN 34ft (10.4m) **LENGTH** 30ft 2in (9.2m)

TOP SPEED 368mph (592kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x 37mm M4 cannon firing through propeller hub, 2 x .5in nose- and 4 x .3in wing-mounted Browning machine guns

Bristol Blenheim IV

The Bristol Blenheim bomber entered RAF service in 1938. However, aircraft were developing so fast that it was already outclassed at the start of WWII. Despite this, Blenheim VIs were used to strike at targets in German-occupied Europe during 1940. The fighter version was the first aircraft to be fitted with airborne radar, and it formed the core of the night fighting force during 1940–41.

ENGINE 2 x 920hp Bristol Mercury XV 9-cylinder air-cooled radial

WINGSPAN 56ft 4in (17.7m) **LENGTH** 42ft 7in (13m)

TOP SPEED 266mph (428kph) **CREW** 3

ARMAMENT 4 x .303in Browning machine guns (fighter version carried four extra guns under fuselage); 1,000lb (454kg) bombload



Curtiss P-40E Warhawk



The US's P-40 was already in production in 1939, for supply to Britain and France, but in combat it was outclassed by almost every other fighter. However, the RAF and USAAF learned to exploit its strengths, using it for close air-support of ground troops.

ENGINE 1,150hp Allison V-1710-39 liquid-cooled V-12 cylinder

WINGSPAN 37ft 4in (11.4m) **LENGTH** 31ft 2in (9.5m)

TOP SPEED 335mph (539kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 6 x .5in wing-mounted machine guns; 1 x 500lb (227kg) and 2 x 100lb (45kg) bombs

Focke-Wulf Fw 190A

In service from 1941 onwards, the streamlined, radial-engined Fw 190 was fast, strong, and heavily armed, with good all-around vision and excellent ground handling. It was superior in every way to the Messerschmitt Bf 109, which, however, it never replaced. In fact, at several stages during WWII, the Fw 190 was better than the existing Allied fighters and was certainly the best fighter which Germany produced. It was easily adapted for "hit-and-run" bombing, ground attack, torpedo attack, tactical reconnaissance, and night fighting.

ENGINE 1,700hp BMW 801 Dg. air-cooled 18-cylinder two-row radial

WINGSPAN 34ft 5in (10.5m) **LENGTH** 29ft (8.8m)

TOP SPEED 408mph (653kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 2 x 13mm machine guns, 4 x 20mm cannon in wings; 1 x 1,100lb (500kg) bomb

